

Japanese Grammar Guide

Particles: は (wa), が (ga), を (wo)

This guide covers essential Japanese grammar concepts including particles, greetings, and foundational sentence patterns.

Chapter 1: Basic Greetings

Japanese greetings change depending on the time of day and the level of formality required.

おはようございます (Ohayou gozaimasu) - Good morning (formal) Used until about 10:00 AM. The casual form おはよう is used with friends and family.

こんにちは (Konnichiwa) - Hello / Good afternoon The standard day-time greeting, used from late morning through late afternoon. This is the most widely recognized Japanese greeting.

こんばんは (Konbanwa) - Good evening Used after sunset and into the evening hours.

さようなら (Sayounara) - Goodbye (formal farewell) A formal farewell that implies a longer separation - you won't be seeing the person again soon. For short departures, Japanese speakers often say じゃあね (jaa ne) or またね (mata ne) instead.

ありがとうございます (Arigatou gozaimasu) - Thank you (formal) The polite form of thanks. The casual form ありがとう is used with close friends and family.

どういたしまして (Dou itashimashite) - You're welcome The standard reply to ありがとうございます.

Chapter 2: Essential Particles

Particles are small words attached to nouns, verbs, and adjectives that indicate grammatical function. They have no direct English equivalent.

は (wa) - Topic Marker

The particle は marks the **topic** of the sentence - what the sentence is about. It indicates known or previously mentioned information.

Example sentences: - 私は学生です。(Watashi **wa** gakusei desu.) - I am a student. - 田中先生は英語の先生です。(Tanaka-sensei **wa** eigo no sensei desu.) - Tanaka-sensei is an English teacher. - 日本語は難しいです。(Nihongo **wa** muzukashii desu.) - Japanese is difficult.

が (ga) - Subject Marker

The particle が marks the **subject** of the sentence - who or what performs the action. It emphasizes new or specific information.

Example sentences: - 猫が好きです。(Neko **ga** suki desu.) - I like cats. (emphasizing "cats" specifically) - 誰が来ましたか? (Dare **ga** kimashita ka?) - Who came? - 雨が降っています。(Ame **ga** futte imasu.) - It is raining.

は vs が

The distinction between は and が is one of the most challenging aspects of Japanese grammar:

は (wa)	が (ga)
Marks the topic (what we're talking about)	Marks the subject (who performs the action)
Used for known or general information	Used for new, specific, or emphasized information
Can replace が in many sentences	Cannot always replace は

を (wo) - Object Marker

The particle を marks the **direct object** - the thing that receives the action of the verb.

Example sentences: - 水を飲みます。(Mizu **wo** nomimasu.) - I drink water. - 日本語を勉強します。(Nihongo **wo** benkyou shimasu.) - I study Japanese. - 本を読みます。(Hon **wo** yomimasu.) - I read a book.

に (ni) - Direction / Time / Location

The particle に indicates direction of movement, specific time, or existence location.

Example sentences: - 学校に行きます。(Gakkou **ni** ikimasu.) - I go to school. - 7時に起きます。(Shichi-ji **ni** okimasu.) - I wake up at 7 o'clock. - 椅子に座ってください。(Isu **ni** suwatte kudasai.) - Please sit in the chair.

で (de) - Location of Action / Means

The particle で indicates where an action takes place or the means by which something is done.

Example sentences: - 図書館で勉強します。(Toshokan **de** benkyou shimasu.) - I study at the library. - バスで学校に行きます。(Basu **de** gakkou ni ikimasu.) - I go to school by bus. - 日本語で話してください。(Nihongo **de** hanashite kudasai.) - Please speak in Japanese.

Chapter 3: Basic Sentence Patterns

です/ます Polite Forms

Japanese verbs and copulas have polite (丁寧語, teineigo) forms used in formal and semi-formal situations:

- ・ **です (desu)** - polite copula (is/am/are)
- ・ **ます (masu)** - polite verb ending

Positive: 食べます (tabemasu) - I eat **Negative:** 食べません (tabemasen) - I don't eat **Past:** 食べました (tabemashita) - I ate **Past Negative:** 食べませんでした (tabemasen deshita) - I didn't eat

Question Formation

Add か (ka) to the end of a sentence to make it a question:

- ・ 学生ですか? (Gakusei desu **ka**?) - Are you a student?
 - ・ 日本語を話しますか? (Nihongo wo hanashimasu **ka**?) - Do you speak Japanese?
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Practice Questions

1. What is the appropriate greeting for afternoon in Japanese?
2. When should you use さようなら instead of じゃあね?
3. What is the difference between は (wa) and が (ga)?
4. Translate: "I study Japanese" using the correct object marker.
5. Which particle marks the location where an action takes place?